

your phone or your PC, share login credentials across devices as well as have a single history if you are using Microsoft Edge. For Android devices, the app notifications show up directly on the desktop, and users can even respond to SMS messages through their computers, without having to unlock the phone. The linking feature also allows Android users to access recent images taken on the smartphone through the computer.

ENABLE SLIDE TO SHUT DOWN

If you want to enable a quick shut-down icon, accessible on your desktop itself, rather than doing it the traditional way or by clicking Alt+F4, you can create a shortcut that enables a pull-down shade that you can simply drag to shut down. To do this, simply right-click on your desktop and then click **New > Shortcut**. Type the following line of code into the ensuing pop-up window – %windir%\System32\SlideToShutDown.exe. A new shortcut will appear on your desktop that you can double-click to bring up the slide-to-shut down pull-down shade. Just use your mouse to drag it to the bottom of your screen and your PC or laptop will shut down.

ACTIVATE HIDDEN GAME BAR

If you're a gamer, the integrated game bar on Windows 10 can come in handy for you. Using the Windows + G command, you can summon the nifty game bar as an overlay on the screen. This essentially switches your Windows PC into gaming mode,

which pools the system's resources to the game and turns off notifications for you to have an uninterrupted experience. Not only does the game bar allow you to record gameplay and capture screenshots, but it also consists of an array of tools including quick panels for adjusting application volume, monitoring resource usage and even playing music on Spotify. You can add a bunch of widgets to the overlay including Audio, Performance, Capture, Spotify, Xbox Social, and others. There's another cool feature where you can make a meme out of a screenshot taken in-game directly from the game bar!

RUN UNKNOWN SOFTWARE IN WINDOWS SANDBOX

Essentially a safe zone for untrusted applications, websites and software, Windows Sandbox is now an in-built solution in Windows 10 for trying out something that could be a malware, adware or security risk. Windows Sandbox was introduced to Windows 10 in the May 2019 Windows update and it creates a secure 'Windows within Windows' virtual environment that is a replica of your 'real' PC. You can browse and use software and websites securely and also copy files in and out of the virtual PC, if you're sure they're safe. However, if a dodgy website does rain down viruses, one simple click shuts the virtual PC down and there's no harm done to your actual Windows installation. To enable this, navigate to the Windows Features control panel and then find **Turn Windows features on or off**.

Now, scroll down and check the box that says 'Windows Sandbox'. Windows will install all necessary files and may reboot your PC. Now, you can simply type Windows Sandbox into the Windows search box and the virtual environment will be set up within no time.

DISABLE ACCESS TO USB PORTS

If you want to protect sensitive information on your computer against being stolen on a pendrive, or if you simply want to disallow people to use your USB ports to protect from possible unknown viruses, you can block the USB ports on Windows 10. No, we don't mean physically blocking it, don't do that... To disable your USB ports (temporarily, of course), type 'Run' in the Windows search box or press **Windows + R**. Now, type regedit to open the registry editor. Look for the **HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE** option and double-click on it. Now, find and click on **SYSTEM > CurrentControlSet > Services > USBTOR**. You'll need to scroll quite a bit to find USBTOR since the folders are in alphabetical order. Within the USBTOR folder on the right, click on **Start** and then a new window will emerge. Here, the default value will be set to 3. Change it to 4 to disable USB storage and click OK. To enable it again, simply change the value back to 3.

DISABLE VISUAL EFFECTS AND ANIMATIONS

One reason your PC could be running slow can be the intensive visual effects and animations on Windows 10 that burden system resources. If you're running an old PC with limited resources, your best option to speed up your system a bit is to turn these off entirely. To disable effects, click on **Start > Run**. Type this command in the bar – sysdm.cpl and click on OK. Go to the **Advanced** tab in the System Properties menu and click on **Settings**. Finally, click on adjust for best performance to turn off visual effects. Click Apply and then OK. To turn off animations, open the Control Panel and select **Optimize Visual Display** under the Ease of Access menu.

